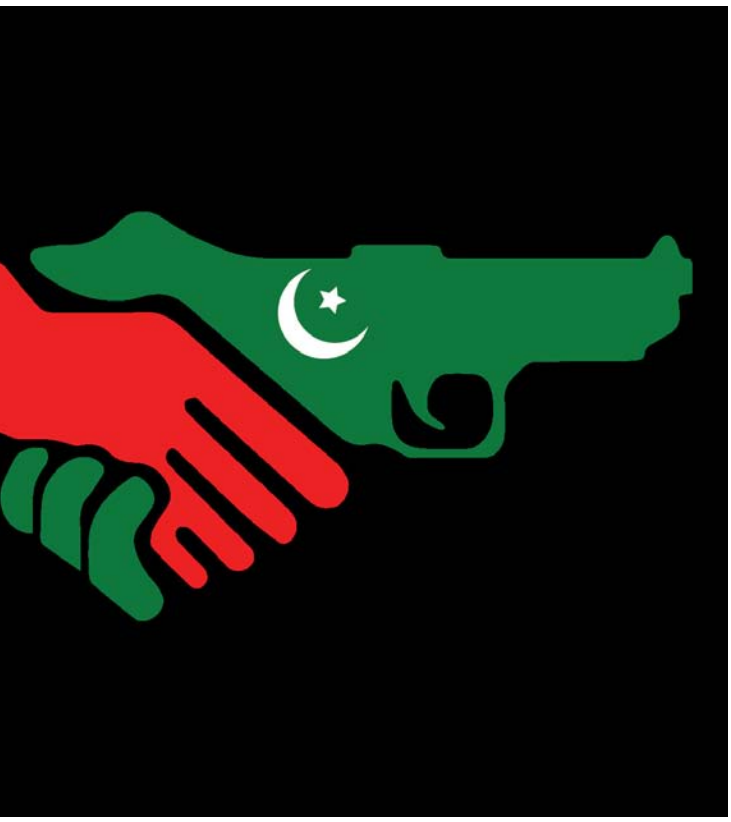


Illustration by **NILANJAN DAS**

AT THE 20TH PARTY CONGRESS IN 2022, XI ENSURED A LASTING NEGATIVE PROJECTION **OF INDIA**

on territories of a number of neighbours, like Vietnam, Japan and the Philippines, and insists on the early "reunification" of Taiwan with the Chinese mainland.

The China Pakistan Economic Corridor (CPEC), announced in April 2015, implicitly endorses Pakistan's illegal occupation of Kashmir, Gilgit and Baltistan. The creation in 2016 of the People's Liberation Army (PLA)'s Western Theatre Command, the largest of China's five military theatre commands, potentially fuses the military strengths of China and Pakistan. It has operational jurisdiction over the entire Line of Actual Control (LAC) and is responsible for Chinese assets and personnel deployed in the CPEC. The China-Pakistan collusion is further underscored by the presence of senior Pakistani and Chinese military officers in each other's Military Operations Directorates. Soon after announcing the CPEC, China gave a clear indication of Pakistan's importance in China's strategic thinking when Chinese leaders conveyed to Indian interlocutors that "India should ease tensions and resume talks with Pakistan, resolve the Kashmir issue and then look to improved relations with China".

Since April 2020, when China intruded into Ladakh in violation of all agreements and treaties, the entire 4,057 kilometres-long LAC has been activated, with the two forces deployed through the tough winters. The PLA has increased its military and air force exercises in Tibet and rapidly constructed infrastructure, including airports, strategic highways and railways, linking Tibet with the mainland. In an unmistakable signal, Xi visited the Western Theatre Command at least on three occasions. Yet neither he nor any other senior leader—except foreign minister Wang Yi (now appointed director of the Central Foreign Affairs Commission), whose job it is—commented publicly on the situation along the border, conveying a deliberate lack of interest in repairing the relationship. China appears prepared for a sustained period of strained relations with India.

Xi's Work Report to the 20th Party Congress, which lays out China's strategic direction for the next five years, reflected that China's tough posture towards India will remain unaltered. It confirmed reports that China is increasing its nuclear arsenal and has plans to enlarge the PLA Strategic Support Force and PLA Rocket Force. Discussing military training and deployments, he said: "This will enable us to shape our security posture, deter and manage crises and conflicts and win local wars." Previous Work Reports have not mentioned "local wars", which refer primarily to conflicts with India. "Shaping" the security posture is something China is already attempting on India's borders. In addition, four of the seven members of China's new Central Military Commission (CMC) have experience of the Western Theatre Command, indicating the importance of the LAC for China. For India, this means fresh military deployments and increased pressure on the borders with the high probability of further clashes. Illustrative is the attempt by 300 PLA soldiers to take over the 17,500 feet-high ridge line at Yangtse near Tawang on December 9.

Very unusually, India merited special negative attention at the 20th Party Congress in Beijing this October. Party Congresses avoid naming individual countries, but this time Xi ensured a lasting negative projection of India. A video clip of the clashes between Indian and Chinese military personnel in Galwan in June 2020 was screened on the opening day for the nearly 5,000 delegates, special invitees and officials assembled in Beijing's Great Hall of the People.

How the big powers realign in a changing world order will pose a challenge for India. China will remain a long-term problem. The composition of the new CMC, the screening of the Galwan clashes video, and the rapid build-up of defence infrastructure in Tibet all suggest that Xi Jinping has made a deliberate choice and is probably planning further military operations against India in the next year or two. How India responds will determine whether Xi has made a strategic miscalculation. ■